ENGLAND · FREE SCHOOL MEALS

On Universal Credit? Your child may eat free at school.

From September 2026 earnings do not decide the meal. Income-related ESA and guaranteed Pension Credit count too. You claim it at school.

WHAT CHANGED, WHAT DID NOT

£7,400

£7,400 a year no longer decides the meal: every Universal Credit household qualifies. It still decides the other help that comes with free meals.

> The government says a family saves up to £495 a year, per child.

WHO DOES NOT GET IT THIS WAY

England

This rule is England only, and for state-funded schools. Scotland, Wales and Northern Ireland run their own schemes. Children in reception, year 1 and year 2 eat free anyway.

> Not qualifying for most benefits does not rule a child out: you ask at the school.

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Not sure whether your household qualifies?

Message us and we will tell you what to ask the school. The claim is made at the school or the local council.

0330 133 1886

General information. The full list of qualifying benefits is on GOV.UK.